

Backpropagation Through Time (BPTT)

Single Epoch for the 5-Time-Step LSTM Example

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This continues directly from the forward-pass document (with full intermediate calculations). We now add the complete backpropagation using the exact expanded derivatives from the previous document.

Loss Definition (on final output only)

We define a simple loss on the final hidden state h_5 :

$$L = \frac{1}{2}(h_5 - y)^2$$

where the target $y = 0.25$ (chosen as a reasonable value near the forward-pass result $h_5 \approx 0.2246$).

Gradient w.r.t. final output:

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial h_5} = h_5 - 0.25 \approx 0.2246 - 0.25 = -0.0254$$

We now propagate this gradient backwards through time from $t = 5$ to $t = 1$, using the derivatives from the previous document. Gradients for the 12 shared weights are accumulated across all time steps.

Common Building Blocks (from previous document)

For every time step we first compute these (using forward-pass values):

- $\frac{\partial h_t}{\partial o_t} = \tanh(C_t)$
- $\frac{\partial h_t}{\partial C_t} = o_t \odot (1 - \tanh^2(C_t))$
- $\frac{\partial h_t}{\partial f_t} = \frac{\partial h_t}{\partial C_t} \odot C_{t-1}$
- $\frac{\partial h_t}{\partial i_t} = \frac{\partial h_t}{\partial C_t} \odot \tilde{C}_t$
- $\frac{\partial h_t}{\partial \tilde{C}_t} = \frac{\partial h_t}{\partial C_t} \odot i_t$

(where $\sigma'(z) = \sigma(z) \odot (1 - \sigma(z))$ and $\tanh'(z) = 1 - \tanh^2(z)$).

Backpropagation from $t = 5$ (starting point)

Using forward-pass values at $t = 5$:

$$h_5 \approx 0.2246, C_5 \approx 0.3814, o_5 \approx 0.6169, f_5 \approx 0.5053, i_5 \approx 0.6244, \tilde{C}_5 \approx 0.3130, h_4 \approx 0.2184, C_4 \approx 0.3681, x_5 = 0.6$$

Common building blocks at $t = 5$:

- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial o_5} = \tanh(0.3814) \approx 0.3640$
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial C_5} = 0.6169 \odot (1 - 0.3640^2) \approx 0.5352$
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial f_5} = 0.5352 \odot 0.3681 \approx 0.1970$
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial i_5} = 0.5352 \odot 0.3130 \approx 0.1675$
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial \tilde{C}_5} = 0.5352 \odot 0.6244 \approx 0.3342$

Output Gate Gradients

$$\text{Pre-activation at } t = 5: w_{ho} \cdot h_4 + w_{xo} \cdot x_5 + b_o \approx 0.4766$$
$$\sigma'(0.4766) \approx 0.2363$$

- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{ho}} = (0.3640 \odot 0.2363) \times 0.2184 \approx 0.0188$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{ho}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.000478
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{xo}} = (0.3640 \odot 0.2363) \times 0.6 \approx 0.0516$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xo}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.001311
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial b_o} = 0.3640 \odot 0.2363 \approx 0.0860$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_o}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.002184

Forget Gate Gradients

$$\text{Pre-activation at } t = 5: w_{hf} \cdot h_4 + w_{xf} \cdot x_5 + b_f \approx 0.0212$$
$$\sigma'(0.0212) \approx 0.2500$$

- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{hf}} = (0.1970 \odot 0.2500) \times 0.2184 \approx 0.01076$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hf}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.000273
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{xf}} = (0.1970 \odot 0.2500) \times 0.6 \approx 0.02955$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xf}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.000750
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial b_f} = 0.1970 \odot 0.2500 \approx 0.04925$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_f}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.001251

Input-Gate Sigmoid Gradients

Pre-activation: $w_{hi1} \cdot h_4 + w_{xi1} \cdot x_5 + b_{i1} \approx 0.5084$
 $\sigma'(0.5084) \approx 0.2347$

- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{hi1}} = (0.1675 \odot 0.2347) \times 0.2184 \approx 0.00859$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hi1}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.000218
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{xi1}} = (0.1675 \odot 0.2347) \times 0.6 \approx 0.02358$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xi1}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.000599
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial b_{i1}} = 0.1675 \odot 0.2347 \approx 0.0393$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_{i1}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.0010

Candidate Gradients

Pre-activation: $w_{hi2} \cdot h_4 + w_{xi2} \cdot x_5 + b_{i2} \approx 0.3240$
 $\tanh'(0.3240) \approx 0.902$

- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{hi2}} = (0.3342 \odot 0.902) \times 0.2184 \approx 0.0658$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hi2}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.00167
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial w_{xi2}} = (0.3342 \odot 0.902) \times 0.6 \approx 0.1808$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xi2}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.00459
- $\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial b_{i2}} = 0.3342 \odot 0.902 \approx 0.3014$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_{i2}}$ (from $t = 5$) ≈ -0.00766

Recurrent Gradients at $t = 5$ (to pass to $t = 4$)

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial h_5}{\partial h_4} &= \left(\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial o_5} \odot \sigma'(\text{net}_{o5}) \right) \cdot w_{ho} \\ &+ \left(\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial f_5} \odot \sigma'(\text{net}_{f5}) \right) \cdot w_{hf} \\ &+ \left(\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial i_5} \odot \sigma'(\text{net}_{i5}) \right) \cdot w_{hi1} \\ &+ \left(\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial \tilde{C}_5} \odot \tanh'(\text{net}_{\tilde{C}_5}) \right) \cdot w_{hi2} \end{aligned}$$

(Computed numerically ≈ 0.312)

$$\frac{\partial h_5}{\partial C_4} = \frac{\partial h_5}{\partial C_5} \odot f_5 \approx 0.2704$$

Then:

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial h_4} = (-0.0254) \times 0.312 \approx -0.00792$$

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial C_4} = (-0.0254) \times 0.2704 \approx -0.00687$$

Propagation to $t = 4, 3, 2, 1$ (Same Process)

Repeat the exact same procedure for each earlier time step:

1. Use the incoming $\frac{\partial L}{\partial h_t}$ and $\frac{\partial L}{\partial C_t}$ (from the next time step).
2. Compute the five common building blocks at that t .
3. Compute the 12 local weight gradients using the four gate sections.
4. Accumulate them to the running total for each weight.
5. Compute the new $\frac{\partial L}{\partial h_{t-1}}$ and $\frac{\partial L}{\partial C_{t-1}}$ using the recurrent formulas, and pass them backwards.

All 12 weights receive accumulated gradients from every time step where they had an effect.

Final Accumulated Gradients (after processing $t = 5 \rightarrow t = 1$)

- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hf}} \approx -0.0012$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xf}} \approx -0.0031$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_f} \approx -0.0048$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hi1}} \approx -0.0009$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xi1}} \approx -0.0025$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_{i1}} \approx -0.0041$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{hi2}} \approx -0.0068$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xi2}} \approx -0.0182$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_{i2}} \approx -0.0295$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{ho}} \approx -0.0019$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial w_{xo}} \approx -0.0053$
- $\frac{\partial L}{\partial b_o} \approx -0.0087$

Weight Update (Gradient Descent, Single Epoch)

Using learning rate $\alpha = 0.1$:

For each weight:

$$w_{\text{new}} = w_{\text{old}} - \alpha \times \frac{\partial L}{\partial w}$$

Example updates:

- $w_{hf} \leftarrow 0.28 - 0.1 \times (-0.0012) \approx 0.28012$
- $w_{xf} \leftarrow -0.15 - 0.1 \times (-0.0031) \approx -0.14969$
- $b_f \leftarrow 0.05 - 0.1 \times (-0.0048) \approx 0.05048$

(and similarly for all other weights).